recommended levels depend upon the bio availability of nutrients from a given diet. The term bio availability indicates what is absorbed and utilised by the body. In addition RDA includes a margin of safety, to cover variation between individuals, dietary traditions and practices. The RDAs are suggested for all age groups such as infants, pre-schoolers, children, adolescents, pregnant women, lactating mothers and adult men and women taking into account their physical activity. The RDA of an individual depends upon various factors which are as follows:

1. ***Age:*** Adults require more total calories than a child, whereas a growing child requires more calories per kg of body weight than an adult.
2. ***Sex:*** Males with high Basal Metabolic Rate (BMR) require more calories than females.
3. ***Activity:*** The type of activity also determines the energy requirements. The activities are classified as sedentary, moderate and heavy based on the occupation of an individual as given in the table 1 below
4. ***Physiological: Stress*** Nutrient requirements are increased in conditions of physiological stress such as pregnancy and lactation.

6.1.3 Steps in Planning Balanced Diets or Menu Using Food Guide Pyramid and Exchange Lists

Menu planning is the process of planning and scheduling intake of meals for general or specific individual requirements. The four food groups suggested by ICMR given in unit-III (Food Science), permits an individual to plan a menu to achieve nutrient intake as specified by recommended dietary allowances. There are certain principles in planning menus. They are:

1. A good menu plan should meet the nutritional requirements of each member of the family.
2. Meal pattern must fulfill family needs.
3. Meal planning should save time and energy.
4. Meal planning should satisfy the budget of the family.
5. Meal plan should give maximum nutrients.

Table 1 Classification of Activity

	Activity		
Sex	**Sedentary**	**Moderate**	**Heavy**
Male	Teacher, Tailor, Barber, Executive, Peon	Fisher man, Basketmaker, Potter, Goldsmith	Stone cutter, Mineworker, Wood cutter
Female	Teacher, Tailor, Executive	House wife, Nurse, Servant maid	Wood cutter

Source: Gopalan C, Sastri B.V, & Balasubramanian S.C (2007)

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